

Summary: Do we still need PMs?

Narrative Summary

The discussion opens with a provocative claim that the traditional Product Manager (PM) role, especially its emphasis on creating year-long, sequential roadmaps based on customer inputs, is becoming obsolete. This model is deemed “ridiculous” in the current technological landscape. The rapid advancements in foundation models and AI capabilities mean that what was impossible just months ago can now be easily achieved, making long-term planning an ineffective approach.

Consequently, the traditional PM’s function of rigid, long-term roadmapping is no longer suitable. The speaker stresses the critical need for organizations to develop extreme adaptability, enabling them to modify their product roadmaps almost instantaneously. This agility is paramount for staying relevant and capitalizing on new technological breakthroughs that emerge at an accelerating pace.

However, a counter-perspective emerges, defending an evolved version of the role. While AI is indeed making the “building” phase of software development increasingly simpler and more automated, the core challenge shifts. The remaining crucial gaps are figuring out *what* to build and, equally important, successfully aligning all stakeholders around that strategic vision.

Ultimately, the consensus points to a transformation of the essential skill set. Whether one comes from a PM or design background, the required expertise now resembles that of a CEO. This updated role is less about managing a sequential roadmap and more about

fundamental strategic leadership: clearly defining “what are we building and why?” for the entire organization.

Key Points

- The traditional PM role, focused on year-long sequential roadmaps, is becoming obsolete.
- Rapid advancements in AI and foundation models invalidate the concept of long-term product planning.
- Organizations must cultivate extreme adaptability to change roadmaps “on the fly” in response to fast-evolving capabilities.
- As AI automates aspects of software development, the core challenge shifts from “how to build” to “what to build.”
- Aligning all teams and stakeholders around the strategic product vision remains a critical function.
- The essential skill for individuals in product-defining roles is evolving towards a CEO-like function: clearly articulating “what are we building and why?”

Notable Quotes

- “The idea of a PM makes no sense in the future.” (00:00)
- “That world is ridiculous. Like right now, the capabilities of foundation models... are just improving such a rapid rate that it makes no sense to have a year-long roadmap.” (00:12)
- “There are things that were impossible to do in November that are actually pretty easy to do right now in March.” (00:25)
- “I think you need to build an organization that’s incredibly adapt at changing the roadmap almost on the fly.” (00:31)
- “as AI makes it easier to build and kind of eats the middle of the software development process, the gap at least for now is figure out what to build and then aligning everyone around what to build.” (00:40)

- “the skill is more like being a CEO now, which is what are we building and why?” (00:55)